

‘not Still Life’

Vaishali Narkar and Sanjeev Khandekar

2025 (ongoing series of works)

www.vaishaliandsanjeev.com

‘Not Still Life ‘

Vaishali Narkar and Sanjeev Khandekar, have presented a new series of works “not Still Life”, that continues their two-decade-long exploration of ecological anxieties.

Comprising six multimedia works on canvas, this collection, primarily executed in acrylic, watercolour, and occasional oil, transcends traditional painting by incorporating and interfacing a fragmented, etched, and sandblasted glass. This innovative approach creates a visual experience of blurring, distortion, magnification, and convergence, effectively mirroring the disorienting nature of our contemporary environmental crisis.

For Narkar and Khandekar, the Anthropocene is more accurately understood as the Capitalocene, a term that underscores their belief that insatiable capitalist greed lies at the root of our planet’s degradation. Their works, therefore, delve into the complex politics embedded within the daily unfolding of environmental catastrophes, tackling issues ranging from global warming and extinction to fossil fuel dependence and genetically modified foods.

Their artistic practice is characterized by its versatility. Over the years, they have seamlessly transitioned between various mediums, from marble inlay and embroidery to large-scale installations and videography, always driven by their commitment to expressing their environmental concerns. This new series, however, marks a distinct departure with its integration of glass, creating a layered visual narrative that reflects the fractured and fragmented nature of our relationship with the environment.

The title itself, “not Still Life”, is a deliberate play on words, a subversive twist on the traditional genre of still life painting. While still life typically depicts inanimate objects arranged for aesthetic pleasure, Narkar and Khandekar’s “not Still Life” vehemently asserts that their focus is on the dynamic, precarious state of life itself. The word “still,” connoting inactivity and silence, is juxtaposed with the urgent

reality of a planet in flux, creating a dark humour that underscores the gravity of the situation. Their statement, “Not Still (life),” emphasizes that their art is a direct reflection of the living world and our place within it.

Sanjeev Khandekar’s multifaceted background as a poet, writer, and avid gardener profoundly influences their collaborative work. His writings, often centred on environmental themes, and his long-standing engagement with tropical gardening, provide a rich source of inspiration. Gardening, for him, is an act of hope, a testament to the resilience of life. This personal connection to nature is evident in their another watercolour series, “Household Roses, Lemongrass and Jasmines in the Cement Jungle of

Mumbai,” which captures the delicate beauty of nature kept alive amidst urban sprawl by the common people.

In “not Still Life”, Narkar and Khandekar have crafted a powerful visual commentary on the Capitalocene, using distorted lenses to reflect the distorted reality of our environmental crisis. Their work serves as a poignant reminder that the “stillness” we perceive is a dangerous illusion, and that urgent action is required to address the profound changes reshaping our world.



Title: *'not Still Life'*

Medium: Acrylic, Oil on canvas with an Interface of a glass etched .

Size: 54" X 42"

Year: 2025